Pro route · Vocabulary and grammar (C2 Proficiency)

All the vocabulary and grammar of the Learning Paths on the Pro route, as they appear on the site.

How to study it

First all the vocabulary, then all the grammar, Learning Path by Learning Path.

Vocabulary: cover the meaning column and define each word in your own words; then write a new example sentence of your own.

Grammar: read how it works, cover the answer column and complete the sentences; then check and read why.

1 · Vocabulary

No new vocabulary: Learning Path 4.

Learning Path 1 · Getting started

Word or expression	Meaning	Example
The turning year · 7		
the nights draw in	it starts getting dark earlier in the evening	*Once the clocks go back, the nights really draw in.*
a nip in the air	a slight coldness in the weather	*There's a nip in the air this morning.*
crisp	cold, dry and fresh (weather); firm and fresh (leaves, food)	*a crisp autumn morning*
a cold snap	a sudden short period of very cold weather	*The cold snap killed the last tomatoes.*
an Indian summer	a period of unusually warm weather in autumn	*We had an Indian summer in October.*
dank	unpleasantly wet and cold	*a dank November afternoon*
to wane	to become gradually smaller or weaker (light, interest)	*The light wanes by five o'clock.*
Harvest and the land · 6		
bountiful	producing large amounts	*a bountiful harvest*
to forage	to search for wild food	*We foraged for mushrooms and chestnuts.*
to gather in (the harvest)	to collect crops when they are ready	*Farmers gathered in the grapes.*
russet	reddish-brown	*russet leaves*
mellow	soft, warm and gentle, not harsh	*the mellow light of late October*
to hibernate	to sleep through the winter	*Hedgehogs hibernate in piles of leaves.*
Mood and season · 5		
wistful	sadly thinking about something you cannot have or that has passed	*Autumn always makes me wistful.*
to hunker down	to stay inside and prepare to wait for a long time	*We hunker down at home when it gets cold.*
cosy	comfortable, warm and relaxing	*a cosy evening by the fire*
the winter blues	a low mood some people feel when the days are short	*Light lamps help with the winter blues.*

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Word or expression	Meaning	Example
seasonal affective disorder	a kind of depression linked to the dark months	*SAD affects many people in northern countries.*

Learning Path 2 · Celebrations around the world

Word or expression	Meaning	Example
Ritual and observance · 8		
observe (a festival)	to follow the customs of a religious or traditional occasion	*Fewer families observe the fast strictly these days.*
observance	the practice of following a religious or traditional custom	*Religious observance has declined, but the festival survives.*
festivities	the activities organised to celebrate something	*The festivities go on until dawn.*
revelry	noisy, lively celebration, often with drinking and dancing	*The night of revelry ends with a fire run.*
solemn	serious and formal, without fun or noise	*All Saints' Day is a solemn occasion for many families.*
jubilant	extremely happy because of a success or celebration	*Jubilant crowds filled the square at midnight.*
pagan	connected with old religions that existed before the main world religions	*Many winter customs have pagan origins.*
syncretism	the mixing of different religions or traditions into one	*Christmas is a textbook case of syncretism.*
Collocations and idioms · 8		
steeped in tradition	full of a long history of customs	*The town is steeped in tradition.*
time-honoured	respected because it has existed for a long time	*a time-honoured recipe*
deeply rooted	firmly established for a long time, hard to change	*The custom is deeply rooted in rural life.*
ring in the New Year	to celebrate the start of the year at midnight	*We rang in the New Year in the main square.*
push the boat out	to spend a lot of money or effort to celebrate	*For my grandmother's eightieth we really pushed the boat out.*
go all out	to make the greatest possible effort	*Our street goes all out for Sant Joan.*
a far cry from	very different from	*Today's Halloween is a far cry from the Celtic Samhain.*
the festive spirit	the happy, generous mood of a celebration	*Not everyone is in the festive spirit in December.*
Word families (for word formation) · 6		
celebratory	adjective: done to celebrate something	*a celebratory dinner*
celebrant	noun: the person who leads a ceremony	*The celebrant lit the first candle.*
traditionalist	noun: someone who wants to keep traditions as they are	*Traditionalists complained about the new parade route.*

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Word or expression	Meaning	Example
commercialisation	noun: the process of making something mainly about money	*the commercialisation of Christmas*
ritualistic	adjective: done in exactly the same way every time, like a ritual	*a ritualistic exchange of gifts*
reverence	noun: deep respect	*The candles are lit with reverence.*

Words you will hear or read (no need to learn them): liturgical · solstice · equinox · effigy · votive · carnivalesque

Learning Path 3 · Where traditions come from

Word or expression	Meaning	Example
Origins · 6		
stem from	to come from or be caused by something	*The custom stems from a harvest ritual.*
be rooted in	to have its origin or basis in something	*Halloween is rooted in Samhain.*
give rise to	to cause something to begin	*Irish emigration gave rise to the pumpkin lantern.*
date back to	to have existed since a time in the past	*The fair dates back to the 1300s.*
folklore	traditional beliefs and stories of a community	*In local folklore, the spirits return that night.*
an invented tradition	a custom presented as ancient but actually quite recent	*Many "ancient" Christmas customs are invented traditions.*
Change · 7		
evolve into	to develop gradually into something different	*A solemn vigil evolved into a street party.*
morph into	to change gradually into something else (informal)	*Halloween has morphed into a shopping event.*
supplant	to take the place of something older	*Pumpkins supplanted turnips.*
fall into disuse	to stop being used or practised	*The custom fell into disuse after the war.*
revive	to make something popular or active again	*A local group revived the old dance.*
dwindle	to become gradually smaller or fewer	*The number of people who observe the fast has dwindled.*
sanitise	to make something less unpleasant or controversial by removing parts of it	*School plays often sanitise the Thanksgiving story.*
Attitudes · 5		
nostalgic	remembering the past with pleasure and some sadness	*My grandmother is nostalgic about the old Castanyada.*
sceptical	having doubts about something	*Historians are sceptical of the popular version.*
contested	argued about; not accepted by everyone	*The meaning of Thanksgiving is contested.*
reverent	showing deep respect	*a reverent silence*
irreverent	not showing the expected respect, often in a funny way	*an irreverent take on Christmas*

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Words you will hear or read (no need to learn them): antiquarian · revivalist · palimpsest · vestigial · Christianised

Learning Path 5 · Plan the day

Word or expression	Meaning	Example
Making it happen · 7		
pull off	to succeed in doing something difficult	*Nobody thought we could pull it off in two weeks.*
iron out	to solve the small remaining problems	*We still need to iron out a few details.*
liaise with	to work together and keep each other informed	*One student will liaise with the primary school.*
rope in	to persuade someone to help	*We roped in my cousin's band.*
oversee	to watch and direct work to check it is done well	*Mr Vidal has agreed to oversee the stalls.*
allocate	to give a share of something for a purpose	*Each stall is allocated a table and two students.*
run smoothly	to happen without problems	*We want the day to run smoothly.*
When things go wrong · 6		
contingency plan	a plan for what to do if something goes wrong	*Our contingency plan is to use the gym.*
a fallback	an option you can use if the first one fails	*The playground is our fallback if the hall is full.*
fall through	to fail to happen	*If the band falls through, we will use a playlist.*
at short notice	with very little warning	*Volunteers may be needed at short notice.*
a bottleneck	a point where things slow down because too much is happening	*The entrance could become a bottleneck.*
logistics	the practical organisation of an event	*The logistics are the hardest part.*
Inclusion · 5		
inclusive	including everyone, not excluding any group	*an inclusive event*
accommodate	to provide what someone needs	*We will accommodate dietary requirements.*
dietary requirements	what people can or cannot eat for health or religious reasons	*All food will be labelled for dietary requirements.*
opt out	to choose not to take part	*Families who prefer not to take part can opt out.*
token	done only to look good, not seriously meant	*We want real participation, not a token gesture.*

Words you will hear or read (no need to learn them): risk assessment · capacity · footfall · signage · stakeholders

Learning Path 6 · Write to the head teacher

Word or expression	Meaning	Example
Proposing and requesting · 6		
with a view to	with the aim of (+ -ing)	*We are writing with a view to organising a celebration day.*
we would welcome the opportunity to	a polite way to ask for a chance to do something	*We would welcome the opportunity to present our plan.*

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Word or expression	Meaning	Example
grant permission	to formally allow something	*We hope you will grant permission for the event.*
at no cost to	without the school having to pay	*The decorations will be made at no cost to the school.*
feasible	possible and practical to do	*We believe the plan is entirely feasible.*
in light of	considering (something new)	*In light of last year's success, we propose…*
Answering concerns · 5		
allay (concerns / fears)	to make a worry less strong	*We hope to allay any concerns about supervision.*
mindful of	aware of and careful about	*We are mindful of the time this takes from lessons.*
safeguard	to protect from harm	*Two teachers will safeguard the younger visitors.*
minimal disruption	very little interruption	*The event will cause minimal disruption to lessons.*
address (an issue)	to deal with a problem	*We have addressed the issue of space.*
Arguing for value · 5		
foster	to help something develop	*The event would foster mutual respect.*
enhance	to improve the quality of something	*It would enhance the school's links with families.*
tangible	real and able to be seen or measured	*The benefits would be tangible.*
far-reaching	having a big effect on many things	*The effects could be far-reaching.*
a case in point	a good example of what you are saying	*Last year's book week is a case in point.*

Words you will hear or read (no need to learn them): with all due respect · notwithstanding · hereby · forthwith

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2 · Grammar

No new grammar: Learning Path 1 and 4.

Learning Path 2 · Celebrations around the world

Grammar for emphasis: inversion and cleft sentences

How it works

- **Negative inversion** for emphasis: *Never have I seen… · Not only does it…, but… · Only when… did… · No sooner had… than… · At no time did… · Little did they know…*
- **Cleft sentences** to focus on one part: *What I love about Diwali is the lamps. · It was in 1863 that Thanksgiving became official. · All I want is a quiet New Year.*
- **Exam tip:** Part 4 usually tests two things at once (grammar + a fixed phrase). Count your words and check that the key word is unchanged.

Practice from the Learning Path, with answers

Sentence	Answer	Why
I have never seen such a spectacular parade. NEVER → ___ such a spectacular parade.	**never have i seen / never before have i seen**	Never + have + subject + past participle.
The festival is beautiful and it is also free. ONLY → Not ___, but it is also free.	**only is the festival beautiful / only is it beautiful**	Not only + auxiliary + subject…, but…
We realised how late it was only when the fireworks started. DID → Only when the fireworks started ___ how late it was.	**did we realise / did we realize**	Only when… + inverted auxiliary.
As soon as the clock struck twelve, everyone started singing. SOONER → No ___ twelve than everyone started singing.	**sooner had the clock struck**	No sooner had + subject + past participle + than.
They had no idea that the party was for them. LITTLE → ___ that the party was for them.	**little did they know / little did they realise / little did they realize**	Little did + subject + verb.
I love the atmosphere of Sant Joan most. WHAT → ___ the atmosphere.	**what i love most about sant joan is / what i love about sant joan most is**	What + clause + is…
Lincoln made Thanksgiving a national holiday in 1863. IT → ___ Lincoln made Thanksgiving a national holiday.	**it was in 1863 that**	It was + focus + that…
You must not light fireworks indoors under any circumstances. CIRCUMSTANCES → Under ___ light fireworks indoors.	**no circumstances must you / no circumstances should you**	Under no circumstances + inverted modal.
The only thing I want this New Year is some peace and quiet. ALL → ___ this New Year is some peace and quiet.	**all i want**	All I want is…
The organisers did not apologise at any point. TIME → At ___ apologise.	**no time did the organisers / no time did they**	At no time + did + subject + verb.

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Learning Path 3 · Where traditions come from

Talking about the past at C2: reporting, would, participle clauses

How it works

- **Impersonal reporting** for uncertain history: *It is believed that… · Halloween is thought to have originated in… · The custom is said to date back to…* (perfect infinitive for the past).
- **would** for repeated past actions (not states): *On that night, people would light bonfires.* **used to** for both.
- **Participle clauses** to compress: *Having moved to America, Irish families… · Carved from turnips, the first lanterns…*
- **Exam tip:** reporting transformations almost always need the perfect infinitive (*to have + past participle*) when the action is in the past.

Practice from the Learning Path, with answers

Sentence	Answer	Why
People believe that Halloween began in Ireland. THOUGHT → Halloween ___ in Ireland.	**is thought to have begun / is thought to have started / is thought to have originated**	is thought + to have + past participle.
People say the festival dates back to Celtic times. SAID → The festival ___ back to Celtic times.	**is said to date**	Present state → present infinitive: is said to date.
It is reported that the first feast lasted three days. REPORTED → The first feast ___ three days.	**is reported to have lasted**	is reported to have lasted.
Every year my grandfather lit the first bonfire. WOULD → Every year my grandfather ___ the first bonfire.	**would light**	would + infinitive for a repeated past action.
After they had moved to America, Irish families started carving pumpkins. HAVING → ___ to America, Irish families started carving pumpkins.	**having moved**	Having + past participle = after they had…
Thanksgiving did not become official until 1863. ONLY → It was ___ Thanksgiving became official.	**only in 1863 that**	Cleft: It was only in… that…
The tradition has almost disappeared. VERGE → The tradition is ___ disappearing.	**on the verge of**	on the verge of + -ing.
It is possible that the custom came from Scotland. MAY → The custom ___ from Scotland.	**may have come**	may have + past participle = past possibility.
People no longer carve turnips. LONGER → Turnips ___ carved.	**are no longer**	Passive + no longer.
The festival changed a lot because of emigration. RESULT → The festival changed a lot ___ emigration.	**as a result of**	as a result of.

Learning Path 5 · Plan the day

The future at C2: formal arrangements and inverted conditionals

How it works

- **Formal arrangements:** *The event is to take place in the hall. · The guests are due to arrive at ten. · We are on the point of confirming the band.*
- **Future perfect / continuous:** *By ten, the stalls will have been set up. · At eleven, the band will be playing.*
- **Inverted conditionals** (formal, very common in proposals): *Should it rain, we will… · Were the hall to be full, we would… · Had we known, we would have…*
- **Certainty:** *It is bound to rain. · There is every chance that… · It is unlikely that…*

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Practice from the Learning Path, with answers

Sentence	Answer	Why
If it rains, we will use the gym. SHOULD → ___, we will use the gym.	**should it rain**	Should + subject + infinitive = if.
If the hall were full, we would open the gym. WERE → ___ full, we would open the gym.	**were the hall to be / were the hall**	Were + subject + to be…
The event has been arranged for 11 December. TAKE → The event ___ on 11 December.	**is to take place / is due to take place**	be to / be due to + infinitive.
We will finish setting up the stalls before ten. HAVE → By ten we ___ the stalls.	**will have set up / will have finished setting up**	Future perfect.
We are about to confirm the band. POINT → We are ___ the band.	**on the point of confirming**	on the point of + -ing.
I'm sure there will be problems with the sound. BOUND → There ___ problems with the sound.	**are bound to be**	be bound to = certain to.
If we had known about the exam, we would have chosen another date. HAD → ___ about the exam, we would have chosen another date.	**had we known**	Had + subject + past participle.
It is very likely that families will come. CHANCE → There ___ families will come.	**is every chance that / is a good chance that**	There is every chance that…
At eleven the band will be in the middle of its set. PLAYING → At eleven the band ___.	**will be playing**	Future continuous.
Please contact Laia if you need anything. SHOULD → ___ anything, please contact Laia.	**should you need**	Formal: Should you need…

Learning Path 6 · Write to the head teacher

Politeness and distance in formal requests

How it works

- **Distancing with past forms:** *We were wondering whether… · We were hoping you might…*
- **Formal requests:** *We would be grateful if you could… · It would be much appreciated if… · Would you be willing to…?*
- **Inversion and formal conditionals:** *Should you have any questions… · Were you to agree, we would…*
- **Passive for diplomacy:** *It has been suggested that… · Concerns have been raised about…*

Practice from the Learning Path, with answers

Sentence	Answer	Why
Please could you reply by Friday? GRATEFUL → We ___ reply by Friday.	**would be grateful if you could / would be grateful if you would**	would be grateful if you could.
If you have any questions, please contact us. SHOULD → ___ any questions, please contact us.	**should you have**	Should you have…
If you agreed, we would start preparations at once. WERE → ___ agree, we would start preparations at once.	**were you to**	Were you to + infinitive.
Can we use the hall? WONDERING → We ___ use the hall.	**were wondering if we could / were wondering whether we could / were wondering if we might**	Distancing past continuous.
Some teachers are worried about supervision. RAISED → Concerns ___ about supervision.	**have been raised**	Diplomatic passive.

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Sentence	Answer	Why
We will make sure the event does not disrupt lessons. ENSURE → We will ___ no disruption to lessons.	**ensure that there is / ensure there is**	ensure (that) there is…
We appreciate your help very much. APPRECIATED → Your help ___.	**is much appreciated / is greatly appreciated / is very much appreciated**	is much appreciated.
The school will not have to pay anything. COST → The event will be ___ the school.	**at no cost to**	at no cost to.
We think the event is very important. ATTACH → We ___ to the event.	**attach great importance / attach a great deal of importance**	attach importance to.
Would you agree to meet us? WILLING → Would ___ meet us?	**you be willing to**	Would you be willing to…?

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